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Lew Soloff

Trumpeter Lew Soloff was born in New York on February 20, 1944. He attended the Eastman School of Music and Juilliard, and was playing professionally in New York by the mid-1960's. His versatility as a lead player and jazz soloist has enabled him to excel in big bands, small ensembles and in the commercial recording studios. Lew's playing is well documented on recordings with Blood, Sweat & Tears, the Gil Evans Orchestra, the Manhattan Jazz Quintet and as a leader with his own ensembles.

Lew was interviewed in Scottsdale, Arizona on April 16, 2000, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming at the Paradise Valley Jazz Party in Scottsdale, Arizona and my name is Monk Rowe. And it's a great pleasure to have Lew Soloff with me, who is one of my favorite players. And I think when I look at your resume I'm trying to find someone who's been doing more versatile work than you over the years. Difficult.

LS: Well thank you. I mean I've enjoyed it. I've really enjoyed all of it. I've enjoyed the different things that I've done.

MR: You stated in a recent liner note that Gil Evans' gig was the greatest one you've done. Does that still hold up?

LS: Sure it does. He was, I mean him and Dizzy were the two, to me, two absolute geniuses. And I was lucky enough to work with Gil for a long period of time, and I was lucky enough to experience what he was like as a band leader, which was basically never telling you what to play, maybe giving you a little hint maybe once a year. But basically never telling you what or how to play and just using you, or having you in his musical organization, as long as you played the way he liked. In other words he picked his musicians to be creative and he allowed them to be creative in his band rather than trying to dictate to them how to play. He let us be ourselves and, rather than tell somebody how to play, he realized that he couldn't get the best out of somebody that way, so if somebody didn't play the way he wanted, he'd get somebody else. Or if his style changed to something other than what somebody in the band wanted to do, the person would leave or he would get somebody else. And that's where the versatility that I had from doing so many things came into play. Because it also opened my mind up to a lot of different kinds of music and so I was open to everything that Gil did. Even if I didn't understand it I remained open to it. And that's why it was my favorite job. Of course along with the incredible freedom that he would give the band came, you know it wasn't as disciplined as a lot of situations, so there were many nights where the band really didn't sound terrific. But when it did it was better than any band I ever played with. When it did.

MR: Wow. That's saying a lot. You said that you started on the trumpet because it was shiny?

LS: Well I thought that. Did you read that in my bio?

MR: Yeah I did.

LS: Did you go on and read further?

MR: Yes I did.

LS: Well, so you want me to state that?

MR: Well yeah.

LS: Yeah my conscious reason for picking up the trumpet was because it was shiny and the odd thing is that I — I don't know how you would put it — but I wound up liking a dull, straight brass-looking horn. As my horn got dull and brass I liked it. Now I also have a beautiful, shiny gold trumpet that I like. I have two trumpets, both of them Bach trumpets, one an old one made in New York City in 1947. I got it second-hand about I'd say close to 20 years ago I got it. And it's a magnificent instrument, but it doesn't have a lot of lead trumpet projection anymore. It kind of mellowed and got darker and richer, but lost the lead trumpet projection. So I found a trumpet that has amazing lead trumpet projection and also plays very well — if I didn't have this other one I'd probably be playing it for everything. But I use that when I play strong lead, like with the Carnegie Hall Jazz Band or something like that. And it's just beautiful and it's shiny. But I was walking home from college one day, back to the dorm, and all of a sudden I started to sing to myself Roy Eldridge's solo from "After You've Gone." And I sung it note for note as I was walking home from school and I realized that I hadn't heard it since I was five years old. And I said wait a minute. I knew that solo cold from when I was five years old. And then I sung a Louis Armstrong solo or two that I knew from when I was five years old. And I said that's why I took up the trumpet. That's why I took up the trumpet. And I was very fortunate that my grandmother and grandfather and my uncle liked those records, because that's what drove me into jazz and that's what drove me into playing trumpet. I listened to Roy Eldridge and Louis Armstrong when I was a little kid. How much luckier can you be?

MR: Yeah. And all those years later, like all of a sudden that came out. That's really great.

LS: You know and then of course I had other early influences. But those were very, very early. And those, now that I'm thinking about it and realizing it, those were the only two guys I heard very early that I was aware of. Those two guys. And then later I heard, I got to be a big Dizzy Gillespie fan. And a little interesting anecdote, a little humor for some of you college people, when I heard Dizzy the first time it was on a record called "Bird and Diz," which is still around on CD. It's a wonderful record on Verve. So when I went to get the Dizzy Gillespie record I went to Sam Goody's and there was a guy who was notorious for knowing jazz records there. He recommended that I get this record with

Bird and Diz. So I got it. When I went home I was listening for the birds on the record. You know? And the music sounded like something from outer space to me. I could not understand it at all. I mean I could hear that Dizzy was a fabulous trumpet player. But I could not understand the music at all. And so if there is some music that you don't understand, Artie Shaw said this, if there's something that you dislike because it sounds very foreign to you, before you make up your mind that you don't like it, I mean if it's something really of a different nature, anything, whatever musical form it's in, don't make up your mind after hearing it once. Listen to it maybe 20 or 30 times and decide whether you like it or not, when you get yourself familiarized a little bit with the language. I mean it's a different thing if you're familiar with the jazz language and you hear somebody play and it doesn't say anything to you, and it's in a language of jazz that you understand — whether it be bebop or whatever — then you can make up your mind quicker. But if something sounds totally foreign and you say what is that, don't turn your back on it until you explore it, I say.

MR: That's good advice. This first playing up in the Catskills must have developed a good sense of humor.

LS: Your questions are great — the playing in the Catskills?

MR: Yeah.

LS: You say must have developed a sense of humor?

MR: I would think so.

LS: My father was in show business, and my mother was a violinist in Vaudeville. My father was a dancer and a comedian. And my whole family had a great sense of humor, and what's left of it has. And I always loved the humor that Dizzy had in his playing, Clark [Terry] has a lot of humor in his playing, and to me humor and warmth kind of go together in a way. Louis Armstrong, his playing was real serious, but he would lighten it up with his conversation and his —

MR: Persona.

LS: Persona, his conversation, his singing. What the Catskills and all that experience did in the various different forms of music is it made me learn how to play these different things and decide what I really wanted to do. Now I really only want to do what I really want to do, at this point, which is basically, more than anything else I like to improvise. I mean there are some exceptional jobs. If somebody calls me to back up a great artist, I'll jump at the chance, because I can learn from the artist. For example when I played behind Frank Sinatra, I would do that at the drop of a hat anytime I got called. Because I'd be doing, first of all playing the greatest arrangements. And the same thing with Barbra Streisand. You know you listen to their phrasing and try to figure out what it is, what is the thing that makes it go straight into the hearts of people when they sing. It's an

amazing thing that very few people have, and singers for the most part have stronger than instrumentalists because they have the advantage of being able to speak lyrics. Of course Miles Davis had an amazing way of interpreting ballads on the trumpet, just amazing, without lyrics. And more modern day and more in a different kind of music, David Sanborn has an unbelievable melodic sense. This is what's always fascinated me. I mean I'm rambling but I suppose you want a little of that.

MR: Sure.

LS: What always fascinated me, more than the guys that could play and run a lot of changes, is the guys who could play a melody, kind of like a singer, and move people. Or play very simply and move people. That's the mysterious part to me. Because I always said if I heard somebody play a whole bunch of notes, oh wow, he can do that and I can't do that. Or wow, boy I'd have to practice to be able to do that. But when you hear Frank Sinatra sing or you hear Louis Armstrong play some simple solo, not his tough ones, they're pretty tough, but some simple solo. Or you hear Dizzy play a beautiful ballad. I mean you hear him play the other stuff and it's impossible. But you hear him play a beautiful ballad. Or Miles. Many of Miles' solos you say to yourself I could play that on the trumpet. But why can't I sound like that? Why can't I sound like that? What has he got? Billie Holiday's voice on "Lady in Satin," was, not really so great anymore, and yet it's the most moving record that I've ever heard by a singer, to me. And that's another thing that I liked when I was a kid. That got right to me when I was a kid. That record. And Sinatra always got right to me.

MR: Were you affected by the rock 'n roll scene that was forming at the time also?

LS: Yes, yes. I was affected by it but I didn't pick up on it because I was advised by adults that it wasn't good music and that I shouldn't listen to it. But had I not been advised by that, I can tell you that "Rock Around the Clock," "Blackboard Jungle," when that music happened in the beginning, that really sent chills up me. I loved that music. I really loved Bill Haley and his Comets. I loved it. It moved the hell out of me — it moved the hell out of every— do you remember that movie?

MR: Sure.

LS: And in the theater how...

MR: It caused some riots in some places too.

LS: I didn't know that.

MR: Yeah. I was just watching a thing on the TV the other day.

LS: I didn't know that.

MR: Actually, more overseas though.

LS: But the music was very moving. Because it was basically out of R&B. And now for example one of the variety things I do, I mean I'm thrilled, I just played lead with Barbra

Streisand over in Australia in New Year's Eve of the Millennium. Of the Millennium. That's a nice place to be New Year's Eve. And I just got called — Branford Marsalis called me up to play this show with Sting. There were four horns, a great band made up mostly of R&B players, and there were about nine stars on the show.

MR: Is this the Rainforest thing?

LS: The Rainforest thing, yeah. Elton John, Billy Joel, Sting, Gladys Knight, Sam Moore who lives here, from Sam & Dave, who lives in Phoenix, Tom Jones, Martha from Martha and the Vandellas. Stevie Wonder sat in. And I'll tell you it was just thrilling. It was thrilling to play this music with these people. And all this stuff goes into my music. It's all a part of my music. Gil Evans made me aware of Jimi Hendrix. Even though I played on the same bill with him back with Blood, Sweat & Tears. I really didn't appreciate him at that time. And the Catskills sharpened up my sight reading. The Catskills was very good for that. Very good for the instant — okay, there's another act tonight, there's another this, there's another that. And I think everything is good to learn with. And it's good to have a wide variety of stuff to learn with. But then I think you've got to make up your mind what you really want to do. If you really want to be good at one area, you've got to make up your mind what you want to do and have the nerve, because it takes a lot of it, to concentrate and to be a master, a real master, or to try to be a master of one thing. I mean it's basically a different thing of being a working trumpet player, which means hello, sure, sub over here tonight, yeah? Wedding tomorrow night? Sure. Okay, a block party? Fine. A jingle here, you know, a recording date. There's one thing to being a working trumpet player, and it's great and it feels really good to be called for that kind of work. But it's another thing to be a working musical personality, where people hire you because of the way you play, not because of the way you play the trumpet, but because of the way you play. Because of the way you can play a song. Because they like your style. I mean the first person who made me aware of it very clearly was Warren Vache actually, who I'm a great admirer of. And I was telling him — this was years ago and I was doing a lot of studio work — and I said gee I really want to get better at playing jazz and this and that. "Well," he says, "look," he says, "it's kind of hard to do when you play the way everybody else wants you to all the time." Gil Evans of course would state it as it's basically hard to be creative when you have to be professional.

MR: Interesting statement.

LS: It's an interesting statement. But when I was doing a lot of studio work, I would be inhibited in my jazz playing. And since this is for educational purposes I figured I'd let that out. But I do think it's good to learn all that stuff. I do.

MR: When you were in your early twenties then, you had a specific goal to be an all-around trumpet player?

LS: That was my goal.

MR: Okay.

LS: Yes.

MR: Well you reached it, that's for sure.

LS: Well I don't think I did but I mean I think for example, as I say, I'm doing this because it's an educational thing, mainly, I'm letting some things out that I wouldn't do in a normal interview. But I was always encouraged, although I didn't have much confidence in it, a couple of my teachers really thought I could have been a fine classical trumpet player. I mean like major symphony level. But the thought of auditioning in that stuff always frightened me. I was actually asked to audition for a major symphony and didn't go. I wouldn't go to the audition. So I never felt like I really developed the classical thing. Now that I realize what it's really about I think I could do it. Because I realized that in the end in any form of music, to be hired, I mean the reason I'm hired for example as a lead trumpet player for many people where I was, and continue to be occasionally, is not because I can play higher or louder or faster than somebody, but because somebody prefers my style. I think a big thing if anybody is interested in playing lead trumpet, the most important thing is time, a sense of time. I think it's one of the most important things in jazz too. I think the time is more important — I read it in "DownBeat," Dizzy said it years ago, I think the time and the rhythm that you play is more important than the notes. But it takes a while to figure that out. You know the feeling is more important than anything. But if you play with good solid time, and a strong conception, I got my conception of lead trumpet playing from three guys basically: From Conrad Gozzo and from Ernie Royal, and then later I realized the magic of Snooky Young, who to me was the greatest jazz lead trumpet player that ever lived — is the greatest lead jazz trumpet player that ever lived because he has the best time of any — he has better time than most drummers. It's unbelievable.

MR: I was hoping you'd say his name.

LS: It's unbelievable. And to find out how good his time is, just sit there in a band, have a four bar rest and then have a quarter note on the first beat of the fifth bar. Like one-two-three-four-four-two-three-four bop. Like that. And you can not figure out where to put it where he puts it, because it's right in the right place. And you just can't put it — it's like the way Sinatra sings.

MR: That's interesting. I mean that's a really simple concept. You would think that putting a quarter note on beat one somewhere would be clearly defined.

LS: An interesting story related to your original question, which is what was my goal, well I wanted to play every kind of music. Every kind of music, I wanted to be able to play it. So I could play classical, enough to do some gigs — not as principal trumpet — but I

could sit in the section. And I could play jazz. And I could play lead. And I could be play weddings. And I could play bar mitzvahs. And I could play — I've done a Greek job, and I've done this and I've done that. But I never played rock 'n roll. So when I got the call from Blood, Sweat & Tears I said well I have to add rock 'n roll to my repertoire. And I think I might meet women. So okay. So I wanted to do it to meet girls and I'd never played rock 'n roll. I wanted to add that to my repertoire of things that I could do.

MR: Was it all that you expected it to be?

LS: After what I had been doing musically it did not turn me on, not compared to what I'd been doing. But I appreciate its place, and I don't think its place in the history of the music scene is really appreciated by a lot of people.

MR: I don't either.

LS: Because it really did bring jazz back to a lot of the public. It really paved the way for bands that really were much better than it, bands like Weather Report. But without Blood, Sweat & Tears to open that door I don't know how long it would have been before a band like Weather Report could have been there. It really did a lot for bringing — it was the first thing that brought a little bit of jazz sound to the mass public in a long time. And for that I'm very proud that I was in the band because of that reason. However, I was playing with Thad Jones and Gil Evans and Joe Henderson and Kenny Dorham, and Clark Terry before I joined that band. And so what I missed was the sense of freedom that a real good improvising situation gives you. And for me — everybody's different — for me, my happiness is in a small band with a lot of blowing space. Because I love to improvise. And now I would say 90, 95 percent of the time, that is what I'm hired to do.

MR: That's good. Was Blood, Sweat & Tears a difficult group as far as — some rock bands have personalities that constantly—

LS: Well let's put it this way. Marriage is not an easy thing for people, to live together for years. And married people usually the husband goes out and he's working all day and in today's world sometimes the wife too. And you only see each other for a few hours at night and a few hours in the morning. When you're in a band and you're on the road, you are with these guys night and day, four or five days a week. And when you take a trip you're with them night and day seven days a week, except when you're sleeping. So naturally personalities are going to grate on each other. It also was a cooperative band which means that the only way to emerge as a leader over a cooperative band is by using all kinds of political techniques that are used. It's a bit ugly but it's the only way that somebody can emerge as a leader is by gathering the votes of others or this or that. There was no leader per se. There was no leader, so some more aggressive personalities emerged as bosses and squelched some of the more creative personalities that were more passive. And I'm not even talking about myself, of course I felt it only in playing the

same tunes over and over again, becoming prisoners of our own hits. Whereas what I'm saying is the real creative forces in that band was a particular arranger to me named Lipsius. I mean Halligan also, but Lipsius was the prime creative arranger in the band. And he is kind of a shy, laid back sort. And oh man, he would bring in this chart or that chart and instead of saying okay we'll do this, okay we'll record this, it was like naaa that's no good, naaa that's no good. And finally he just stopped.

MR: Yeah, he had less arrangements on those records than he should have.

LS: Near the end, yeah. Of course. Because he didn't want to bring something in and have it put down. And he was the real, amazing creative energy in that band. Actually so was Al Cooper, before I was there. I loved his songs. But it doesn't matter. I'm always of the mind that if a band is allowed to just continuously try to be creative they're better off than if they have a hit and they try to keep following that formula. I'm even of that mind with the Manhattan Jazz Quintet which I'm in, which you may have heard of or may not. It's a band that's extremely popular in Japan, a jazz quintet. We made a record in the early eighties, maybe '84 or so. The record was projected to sell about 8,000 copies. Within several months it had sold well over 80,000 copies, and shortly after that it went up to about 160,000 copies. And when you're talking about a country the size of Japan you multiply it by ten to imagine what it would be like in sales here. And for a jazz record, that's a lot. Well now we're making our 24th record as a quintet. We'll be doing that in May or June. Our 24th record as a quintet. We just did our eighth outgrowth of the quintet, a big band album, the eighth one, so that's 24, eight big band records, I did five solo records, give you $125 if you can find one — no, no. I did five solo records out of that, eight big band records, 24 quintet records, which will be shortly 24, a couple of orchestra records, all stemming out of this, plus many related projects with other artists that all came out of that for me. But the down side of it is that the band, which is on a level where it still works in Japan but not on that high level of hit that it was back in the late and mid eighties, they basically, and I'm not the leader, they basically are of the mind that we still have to follow the original formula of the band. And I think if we had just changed it radically we would be enjoying the music more and getting better critical approval. But I'm not the leader.

MR: Well what is the format?

LS: The format was originally and still is, at that time jazz was getting very, very avant garde in Japan and very out. And there was a feeling by some people that a group had to come together and play some of the straight ahead stuff made popular by some of the great groups like Horace Silver, Art Blakey, da- da- da- da- da, in a little bit of a different way. And so we did an album and it was, outside of Blood, Sweat & Tears, I have never been involved in a band that had that kind of reaction to it. Never. I mean Blood, Sweat &

Tears of course was in a class by itself. You know how big that band was at the time. That was a real trip. We were the second biggest band in the world to the Beatles. But this band was very far removed from that kind of success, but way more successful than anything else I was with outside of BS&T. And this one was called MJQ. They call it MJQ. So maybe if I change my name from Lew Soloff's Food Group to LSFD maybe something will happen. Yeah, maybe some initials, maybe that'll do it. Anyway just to let you know where my head is at with music, I like to improvise in many contexts. I like to play straight ahead jazz but I also just as much like to play more of a world beat, narrow music in a way, which is kind of funk-fusion, R&B branched, in other words there's a whole area of music, and some is finally being creative, that has some of the complexity and intricacies and depth — that's the word I'm looking for — of the straight ahead music. The hard thing about the music based on some kind of electric instruments is that often times volume is a negative factor. Because if the volume is so high that you have to play loud all the time to be heard, it's very hard to think creatively. Because part of music is having that dynamic thing from five p's to five f's, and being able to use them with it have the whole band come down and up because they can hear you. But if an electric rhythm section is playing, except in very few hands, these things can't happen. Because the instrument control over the volume is not there as much as the others. And I think that's one of the biggest problems with that. But talk about an intense groove? Whew. You should have heard that band behind the R&B acts. There were two guitarists, there was Steve Cropper and Nile Rogers. And Steve Cropper invented a lot of that stuff and Nile Rogers is fabulous. The bass player was Nathan East. The drummer was Narada Michael Walden, and the — I can't pronounce his name right, Greg Phillinganes was the piano player. Also Leon Pendarvis was a piano player and a guy named Frank — I can't remember his last name right now because I just met him. And it was an astounding rhythm section. Astounding. And there was a great percussionist there too.

MR: How much time did you have to get this whole thing together?

LS: We rehearsed — by the way, you never saw such intensity in musicians. Everybody was working for basically the Rain Forest Charity. It was either a nice nominal payment, but not considering the hours, but it was a nice nominal payment. It was a generous nominal payment, or else twice this payment was offered in value of tickets and things like that. And high-fallutin dinners and stuff like that. But even though many people donated their services totally, and took just the ticket and the dinner, many people did that, I never saw anything like it. We rehearsed for 13 hours straight the first day. There was maybe a half hour to 45 minutes taken for lunch; a half hour to 45 minutes taken for dinner. But outside of that there wasn't any breaks during the day at all. And the next day we did ten and a half hours.

MR: Who put all the music together, chart-wise, for the horns and all that?

LS: Well it was difficult. There were 30 songs. There were several guys that did it. Frank, the keyboard player did some of it. There was another guy on the west coast that at the last minute was called in too. We basically, since they were covering a lot of records, in other words like they would do famous R&B recordings done by other artists, like it was an homage to Rhythm & Blues. So Sting did one of his own songs, but for example they would all do real R&B songs. And the charts were basically taken off the records, which was just time consuming. But it all had to be done so they got various people to do it. And then, here's one for you all students there, and then the singers changed the keys on many of the charts. And then they changed them again.

MR: Oh no.

LS: And then they changed them again and again. And then they changed them again and again. I'm telling you we had to read things a minor third down, a fifth up, a tone down, a whole tone down, a half a step up, and the band did it like that. The whole band.

MR: That's intense.

LS: Yup.

MR: I guess that's why they had the all-stars, huh?

LS: The band just did it like that. It didn't matter. The key was just played.

MR: God. That gets you on the edge of your seat, doesn't it?

LS: You don't want to mess up. Nobody wanted to mess up. And the band was so good that everybody, almost everybody messed up a little just listening to the other people. But it was really an educational experience. It was really something. I still think about some of the singing I heard.

MR: Let me take you back to a couple of things in your career. You did a thing with Ornette Coleman, "Celebration?" In '89 was it?

LS: Probably.

MR: Okay.

LS: You mean the thing with the Kronos Quartet?

MR: Yeah.

LS: Right.

MR: It just seems like another end of the spectrum for you.

LS: I didn't do it — it was a concert. I didn't play with the Kronos Quartet but they opened and I did this thing. That made me nervous. That really, really made me nervous. He wrote a piece for solo trumpet that was so difficult. Oh it was so hard. And we did it in Carnegie recital hall and I was very, very nervous. I don't know what kind of job I did. I think I could approach it with a different attitude now and do better, I really do. But it's funny, when you're not doing something for a while, it makes you nervous. When I'm

playing live a lot and then all of a sudden I have to record, if I'm not in front of the recording studio microphone I get nervous in front of the recording studio microphone. If I'm playing in front of the recording studio microphone all the time it's second nature, then you go out and play live and you get nervous if you haven't played live in a while. But the classical thing, somehow I've always had a little bug about it, about like it has to be perfect.

MR: Well the definition of a mistake is much more absolute in that kind of music.

LS: I don't know, but it always — I just never — that's why I didn't go into the field. I never felt relaxed with it. I think I could go into it now because it's really the same thing as jazz, you just enjoy the music. The only thing that would stop me is the fact that in the classical thing there's a certain kind of thing necessary to play the notes that somebody else wrote and play them with very close to absolute accuracy and then there's a certain kind of abandonment that I want in my jazz playing. I want to have the abandonment to be able to play something, even if I can't play it, I go for it. Even if there's some line that strikes me and I know I can't play it, it doesn't matter, I'll still try to play it. And sometimes the intention of the line — sometimes it comes out. But sometimes the intention of the line, even if it doesn't come out is exciting to hear because the audience can pick up on the intent. And I find that if I practice too much for absolute accuracy and get my mind too much into that — in other words if I've been playing a lot of precise lead trumpet, it usually takes me a few days to completely loosen up in my jazz playing again. As when I'm playing jazz it will usually take me a couple of rehearsals to focus in and get that lead thing just right. Different head. The lead thing is more like playing classical music.

MR: What kind of head do you have to have on to be comfortable in these kind of jazz party situations?

LS: Improvising. Just enjoy the music. I think that's it. I just enjoy the music. The other thing is, to me, to realize that when you're playing with a rhythm section, stop thinking of yourself as a soloist and start thinking of the whole band as a group. And that way you don't have to play every second. See it's what you don't play that's also extremely important I think. In other words if the rhythm section is really grooving, you can play two notes, you can lay out for seven beats, or 14 beats, you can lay out, and then come in with the right note and it's very effective. If you're playing — so many players play almost continuous streams of eighth notes. And to me they all wind up sounding basically very much the same. And they do not excite me. There are some special players that play a lot of them, but they're few and far. In other words, most people just either imitate that play that way, or they play, you know it's all technique and look how I can run through the changes. There's so much of that. And people forget about the feeling and they forget

about time, really strong time, and they forget about melodic concept, horizontal concept. There's a lot of people there that are thinking very vertically. Of course I could be biased, since it's something I've never really taken to. You know since it's not excited me that much I haven't gravitated to it and try to learn it in great depth. So again, for educational purposes I'm saying it's not sour grapes, because I can't seem to force myself to get into that. It's not my love. For somebody whose love it is, it's fantastic. I mean an example of somebody who can do that but does it with great emotion, to me, of course John Coltrane. But somebody around today that does that and does it with great emotion and has it all to me is Dave Liebman. Absolutely incredible harmonic knowledge, can play all over the place, see but David, in addition to playing a lot of notes at one time, he comes out of Trane. And if you listen to a great Trane solo, sometimes you'll hear Trane playing a million notes but then, after playing all these choruses of a million notes, he might all of a sudden land on one note or one note that has a lot of harmonics in it, or a particular sound he's getting on it, and what is the most exciting peak of the whole solo? That is. And Miles is an example of somebody who, I mean yeah there's some records where he plays fast magnificently, but that really wasn't what it was, it was his sound that gets you. So the right note in the right place is what it's all about.

MR: Well said. It's a great concept. One more thought I'd like to ask you —

LS: Feel it. That's what I mean.

MR: Feel it. Okay. In the BS&T days, was it tough learning tunes because you had — I'm just guessing — maybe you had half the band that read music and some of the guys in the band that didn't? Did they have a different way of learning?

LS: Everybody read music in that band.

MR: No kidding?

LS: Everybody could read well in that band. Jimmy Fielder was the bass player, he was a hell of a musician. All the horn players could read. The only one who couldn't read well was Steve Katz. Hi Steve. No he couldn't read well, but he played with a lot of feeling. But everybody could read in that band.

MR: Dick Halligan?

LS: Dick Halligan was a studio musician, writer, out on the west coast. Great musician.

MR: When you did the solo on Lucretia Macevil, did they make you play a bunch of them and then choose your...

LS: That solo was actually — God that solo, there were so many touches in that solo. Bobby Colomby produced that tune, and he would punch in here and punch in there, and that solo was very, very constructed by Bobby. I mean I like the way it came out, but it was very constructed by Bobby and I always used to think that that was wrong, but I don't think it's so wrong. I mean I don't want to mention names, I don't want to give it away,

but there's a lot of incredible pop records that are made and they're constructed that way. My favorite playing, for the record, on that is just where they fade me out. That's when I start to really go, just before they fade me out. I'd like to hear what I played after that.

MR: I'll bet the tapes are still around somewhere.

LS: I'm sure they are.

MR: It would be a nice little historic artifact to get your alternate takes on that. Let me ask you about your new record here, which I thought I would put on—
[audio interlude]

MR: One of your tunes, isn't it?

LS: Yes. This is written by me and Rob Mounsey. Rob Mounsey is a great keyboard player and a great arranger/producer in New York. He's done a lot of stuff. He's done stuff for Sinead O'Connor, Madonna — he's a brilliant, brilliant musician. I've played on two of his records. And this part he wrote. This is the bridge.

MR: So you brought this tune to him and like, need a part or here? Or just kind of a collaboration?

LS: That part he wrote, all the rest of it, including the [scats] the rhythm feel I wrote. Well you notice he did four or five arrangements on this record, Rob. I brought the tune to him, but since he was helping me with the record he said it needs a bridge, you know, and then he played a little something on the piano. He said maybe you could do two voices. I said, Rob, write a bridge, I'll give you co-composer. Write a bridge. Like that he writes a bridge. It's nice. I haven't heard it in a long time.

MR: You haven't heard it in a long time? Yeah. I'm looking forward to checking the whole thing out. That's a Harmon mute there?

LS: The whole record is in a mute.

MR: Yeah. Now you made a side comment a little while back about trying to find your other records.

LS: Yeah, they're hard to find.

MR: Is it a struggle trying to keep things with record companies — or find record companies that will record you?

LS: Oh of course it is. And of course the whole world is changing with the record industry now because the Internet is changing that. So who knows what's going to be going on and what the story's going to be now with records soon. You know what I mean? I mean the Internet could change the whole picture. We don't know.

MR: You think it's a positive thing?

LS: Yeah I do. Because I don't think artists, unless they became major stars and could demand incredible deals, I don't think artists really ever got enough compared to what record companies got from royalties and stuff like that. I mean there's all kinds of

ridiculous stories but rare is it that you ever recoup royalties from a record. They set it up that way. You know they just set it up that way. And if you do your own CD, CD's — it's trouble to set up a company. I mean the biggest, the thing is you can set up the company but distribution, that's the hard one. There's still no way to have the power of distribution that a major label could give you, something like that.

MR: Have any words of advice for young trumpet players or just musicians trying to break into the business these days?

LS: Yeah. I do. First of all you have to decide what you want to do, whether you want to be an instrumentalist, a trumpet player per se or whether or not you have a love of jazz to the point where you want to be a stylist. You have to decide what you want to do. If you want to be an in-demand cat, and I include women in that, to play any kind of job for anybody, the key is versatility and very fast sight reading ability. There are people that learn to read lines ahead of where they're playing. Very few people have this ability but some people do, culminating in maybe a whole page ahead, almost like photographing the page with your mind. But most people that can do that learn it when they were very small. But it's a good thing to learn to read, if possible, a bar or two ahead, or even more if possible, than where you're playing. It's a skill that's hard to develop, I don't have it, I read maybe a couple of beats ahead of where I'm playing or something. But if you can do that, if you can become a superb sight reader, if you want to become a horn for hire or a musician for hire, that's one of the prime things you need to do. Because people want to get — if you want to record, people have to get their stuff together right away, and you need to be a very quick learn that way and reading helps a lot. And there's another kind of musician who could be a for-hire musician as a side man, and I think this combines with being a stylist, where you may not have to read as well but you still have to be a good reader if you're going to play in somebody else's band. Because somebody else wants to do new material, and if the whole band can learn the material in two hours and you need to spend four days learning it because you can't read, if there's another person plays as well as you they're going to get the job you know? On the other hand if you're such a super excellent player that somebody wants your feeling on it, you'll get the job even if you're a slow reader. But that's rare. It exists, but rare. And then, if you're hooked on music and you want to really express yourself playing your music you should start getting bands together, ensembles together, whatever it is you like to play and you should start assuming the role of leadership at a young age and learn how to play your own music, in your own group, and how to get a whole concept of what you like. Develop your whole concept of what you like and go for it. Don't have any doubts about it. And the final piece of advice is that it's a very competitive field, everybody would like to have a good time rather than go to work and do a job they don't like from nine to five, so if

you love it enough and you really want to do it, work really, really hard at it. Work really hard at it. And if you don't have the ability to do that, if you don't have the ability to work hard at it, it's going to be a very dangerous field for you to make a living. There's no guarantee of making a good living anyway in it, because it fluctuates. But in other words the passion has to overcome all the possible problems. It's very possible to make a great living at it also. But the passion has to overcome all these problems. It has to become more important than a comfortable, meaning rich, lifestyle. It has to be more important to you than that, and then you might get the rich lifestyle from it.

MR: That's great advice.

LS: Otherwise don't go into it.

MR: All right. Well it's been a great pleasure talking to you today.

LS: My pleasure to talk to you.

MR: And best of luck in your future projects. It'll be interesting to see where your name shows up next.

LS: Well there should be a record coming out, hopefully called "Rainbow Mountain," which is that funk-fusion kind of groove. Hopefully somebody in America will pick it up.

MR: Well we will, we'll look for it.

LS: Okay. Thank you so much.

MR: Thank you.